

New Federal Data Shows How U.S. Public School Students Are Doing

From: NPR World Mined: 2026-10-07 5 min read

A large federal **survey** called the **Civil Rights** Data Collection gives one of the most complete pictures of how students are treated in America's public schools. The newest report covers the 2023-24 school year and about 49.7 million students in more than 97,000 schools.

The government has gathered this kind of information for over 50 years. It helps the U.S. Education Department check whether schools protect students' **civil rights**. The Trump administration released the latest data on Aug. 31, six months later than promised.

Two researchers, Maithreyi Gopalan of the University of Oregon and Dan Losen of the National Center for Youth Law, studied the data and shared findings with NPR.

Preschool grew. About 1.5 million children were in public preschool, a 12% jump from 2021-22. Gopalan said some states are investing more in early learning. At the same time, K-12 **enrollment** fell almost 1%.

Suspensions rose. About 2.5 million students received out-of-school **suspensions**, up by about 100,000. Losen said students missed over 14 million school days because of them. He said many **suspensions** are for minor problems, such as being late, and that support for students and better teacher training can work better. The data also show Black students lost far more school days to suspension than white students.

Students with disabilities now make up 19% of public school students, up from 17%.

For the first time since the 1970s, the **survey** counted teachers by race. Teachers are 75% white, 9% Black and 11% Latino, very different from the students they teach.

The administration chose not to release data it collected on nonbinary students, citing an **executive order**. Losen criticized that choice. The Education Department did not answer NPR's questions about it.

Word Treasure

survey -- A set of questions or a count used to collect information from many people or places.

civil rights -- The rights every person has to be treated fairly and equally under the law.

enrollment -- The number of students signed up to attend a school or program.

suspensions -- Punishments in which a student is not allowed to attend school or class for a time.

executive order -- A written instruction from the president telling government agencies how to act.

Background you need

The Civil Rights Data Collection is a federal survey that asks public schools across the country to report information about their students and staff.

Civil rights laws say schools must treat students fairly no matter their race, sex or disability.

The U.S. Education Department uses the survey to check whether schools are following those laws and to spot groups of students who may be treated unequally.

Researchers and the public also study the results to see how things like preschool, discipline and teacher qualifications are changing.

Break it down

LEAD: A huge federal survey shows how students are treated in U.S. public schools

KEY EVENT: Newest Civil Rights Data Collection released for the 2023-24 school year

+ WHO: Education Department data, analyzed by researchers Maithreyi Gopalan and Dan Losen

+ WHAT: More preschoolers, slightly fewer K-12 students, more suspensions

+ WHEN: Data released Aug. 31, six months late

EVIDENCE: 1.5 million preschoolers; 2.5 million out-of-school suspensions; over 14 million missed days; disabilities up to 19%

EVIDENCE: Teachers are 75% white, 9% Black and 11% Latino

OPEN QUESTION: Data on nonbinary students was withheld, and the department did not answer NPR's questions

Why it matters

The survey is one of the main ways the country checks whether public schools treat all students fairly. Its findings on suspensions, preschool and teachers can shape how schools and lawmakers try to help students.

Test what you remember

1. About how many students does the newest Civil Rights Data Collection cover?

- ☐ (A) About 14 million
- ☐ (B) About 97,000
- ☐ (C) About 49.7 million
- ☐ (D) About 1.5 million

2. Which school year does the newest report cover?

- ☐ (A) 2023-24
- ☐ (B) 2021-22
- ☐ (C) 2025-26
- ☐ (D) 2019-20

3. By how much did public preschool enrollment grow compared with 2021-22?

- ☐ (A) It grew 2%
- ☐ (B) It doubled
- ☐ (C) It grew 12%
- ☐ (D) It fell almost 1%

4. According to Dan Losen, what can work better than many suspensions?

- ☐ (A) Closing schools early
- ☐ (B) More homework
- ☐ (C) Support for students and better teacher training
- ☐ (D) Longer school days

5. What share of public school students now have disabilities?

- ☐ (A) 9%
- ☐ (B) 19%
- ☐ (C) 17%
- ☐ (D) 75%

6. What information did the administration choose not to release?

- ☐ (A) Data on preschool
- ☐ (B) Data on teachers' race
- ☐ (C) Data on suspensions
- ☐ (D) Data it collected on nonbinary students

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: A 3: C 4: C 5: B 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Dan Losen, National Center for Youth Law: Says many suspensions are for minor problems and that support for students and better teacher training can work better; criticized withholding the nonbinary data.
2. Maithreyi Gopalan, University of Oregon: Says some states are investing more in early learning, helping preschool grow.
3. Trump administration: Chose not to release the nonbinary student data, citing an executive order.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):